

Red kangaroo

Macropus rufus



Standing up to 7 ft (2 m) tall, the red kangaroo is the world's largest marsupial and the largest land animal in Australia. Its huge, muscular hindlegs enable it to hop along at speeds of up to 35 mph (60 km/h) for several minutes, covering several feet in a single bound, with its three-foot-long tail held out behind as a counterbalance.

Australia's sandy plains, semideserts, savanna, and scrubland are extremely harsh environments, but the red kangaroo is well adapted to these hot, dry, and largely barren landscapes. Mostly active at dawn and dusk, it retreats to the shade of trees or rocks during the hottest part of the day. It repeatedly licks its forelegs to regulate its body temperature—as the saliva evaporates, the blood flowing just under the skin is cooled.

Boomers and mobs

A highly nomadic species, the red kangaroo has no fixed home range. It roams large distances in search of fresh grass and leaves. The kangaroo lives in small groups of up to 10 animals that usually consist of one large adult male, known as a boomer, and several smaller females,

which are only about half as heavy, plus a few young. If food is plentiful, several groups may join together to form a larger unit known as a mob.

Arrested development

Breeding is determined by the availability of food—red kangaroos may not breed at all during droughts. However, a reproductive system in which a female can have three offspring at the same time all at different stages of development allows maximum production of young when times are favorable. A female gives birth to a single baby following a short gestation of 32–34 days. This tiny joey climbs into its mother's pouch, attaches to a teat, and continues to develop. The female then mates again within days of giving birth, but development of this new embryo is suspended until the female's existing joey leaves the pouch at about eight months old. It will still be suckling from its mother when the next baby is born—the female's teats are able to produce milk independently of one another, allowing her to provide milk specific to the needs of each offspring.

More than **11.5 million** red kangaroos live in Australia's hot, arid landscapes

◀ SWIFT HOPPER

Hopping is very energy-efficient, especially at higher speeds. The hindlegs act like springs and so the thrust delivered when leaping uses little energy.

▷ POUCHED JOEY

The joey first pokes its head out of the pouch when it is about five months old. It leaves the pouch at eight months, but suckles milk for another four months.



- ↔ 3–5 ft (1–1.6 m)
- ⚖ 55–200 lb (25–90 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Grasses, leaves
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